

Research Paper: The Lessons from Job

OT-5121: Old Testament

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Job is viewed as one of the best books of the Bible according to my professor and president at Master's University. I agree with him. Job has so much wisdom and teaches us so much about how to live our lives and why things happen. There are many things we can learn such as we cannot know why certain things happen. The reason for this is because Job never knows why he had to suffer. Also, we can know that suffering may happen because there is a test by Satan on us. There are several questions that we need to answer: why is there suffering, what is revealed to us and what is not, the meaning of life, what is wisdom, what is truth, etc.

The first source¹ I want to quote is about the fear of the Lord. This source says that Job may be a sarcastic response to Wisdom literature. And I believe this can be true. Wisdom literature generally says, "Be good, and good things will happen." But Job is actually the opposite, "Be good, and Satan will test you and bad things will happen to you!" The entire book

¹ Greenwood, Kyle R. 2023. "The Fear of the Lord Is Wisdom?": A Consideration of Job 28 as a Sarcastic Response to the Wisdom Tradition." *Hebrew Union College Annual* 94: 21–47.
<https://search.ebscohost.com/login.aspx?direct=true&db=lsdar&AN=ATLAIACO240430000498&site=ehost-live>.

of Job is about Job rambling about why he is innocent and why he shouldn't be suffering. It's completely opposite from what Wisdom Literature is, and is a good reason for why it may be a sarcastic response as the source says. However, I would like to show that occasionally in the wisdom literature, it says that the righteous will suffer and that definitely, in the wisdom literature, there is always a battle between good and evil. In proverbs, we can see that it is better to suffer and be disciplined than to be lazy and careless. Proverbs would teach that the rod of discipline is necessary for love and for good living. However, it is very true that the Proverbs teach the righteous people will succeed and be wealthy. This is in congruence with Job in the beginning of the book of Job. The conclusion I want to make with this source is that, yes, the righteous will suffer, but suffering and sorrow of Godly nature leads to repentance and to a fruit of righteousness. So Proverbs and Job is correct, and Job is sarcastic in some ways but maintains the style of the rest of the Bible.

The next source² talks about how postmodernity may be the topic of Job. This is so true because postmodernism says there is no meaning to anything because anything goes, and we see a postmodernist come up in the Book of Job as one of the four characters who talk to Job. The

² Stala, Józef, Elżbieta Osewska, and Krzysztof Bochenek. 2023. "The Sufferings of the Biblical Job as an Icon of Postmodernity: The 'Loneliness' of God and the Human Being in a Consumerist Paradise." *Journal of Religion and Health* 62 (1): 327–37. doi:10.1007/s10943-021-01323-5.

postmodernist says in Job that is completely contradictory - something along the lines of, "There is a guy who is talking too much because he has his mouth shut." What the postmodernist in Job and in the world is going to tell us is that Job is suffering for no reason because there is no such thing as truth, anything goes, and there is no meaning to life. Thus, Job is arguing, "Yes, there is truth! There is a God! And there is good and wrong, and I did good and I deserve happiness and a good life!" The postmodernist is saying, "Job! There is no good or evil. Everything happens for no reason and we don't know why and will never know why things happen. It's arbitrary. A rock is falling and rising at the same time. Forget about finding out the reason to your suffering!" And the fact that Job is never answered for why he suffered and how the good suffer and the good don't suffer in the wisdom literature and even in life show us that postmodernism has a grain of truth. To find out the truth, we must believe there is a truth or not. But to believe there is no truth is to say the truth is there is no truth. Thus, postmodernism cannot be true. But to show that the postmodernist has a point can be seen in that we don't know why things happen in our lives, and we will never know the backstory to our story on earth because Satan and God are duking it out. Thus, we can say Job is somewhat postmodernist as the source says, and we can

understand the truth that there is a lot of truth and deep wisdom in Job and in God and the world and that we will never know all the truths of God.

The third source³ talks about the story of Zeno, a Greek myth, I believe, and compares it with Job. The story of Zeno is that he is desperately searching for meaning, according to the source, and after a minor accident, he “takes his life.” This is because he could not find the meaning, unfortunately. However, this is in contrast with Job, who reacts differently to the stressors in his life. After standing against cataclysmic losses, he survives and eventually thrives. The source says that this is relevant today because of “so many young people striving to find themselves.” I agree to this. So many people are trying to escape from norms and tradition and custom and convention in order to do something different so they can be liberated from their past and from all these rules and be something that gives them pleasure. However, Job shows what the meaning of life is and the way to true happiness. One thing that I don’t agree with many people is that the blessed wealth that Job gets at the end of the story of Job is a sign that God blessed Job because of his endurance. I think that is possible. However, I think that even if Job were to suffer and not be rewarded at the end, he would be rewarded in heaven

³ Kaplan, Kalman J. 2023. “The Biblical Job Against Zeno the Stoic: Living Purposively Versus Dying for Meaning.” *Journal of Religion and Health* 62 (1): 316–26. doi:10.1007/s10943-022-01539-z.

and the story would still be considered wisdom literature. This is in congruence with the verse in Hebrews that says they were looking forward to the promised land but never received it in their lifetime. The meaning of life is shown in both stories - Zeno and Job. Zeno shows the antithesis of Job, and Job shows what the correct way to live is. Zeno is trying to show the way of the Stoics. And the Christians were influenced by the Stoics a lot. One of the things I want to believe is that Christian theology is not in a bubble - we are influenced by secular science, engineering, and people. Thus, the Stoics influencing the Christian theology should not be dismissed or considered a bad thing. Infinity - we use this in theology, and it is a mathematical term. The stoics ultimately say that we should not be moved by anything - if something happens, good or bad, we should let it go through us and not affect us. This is Christian. However, because we are finite, we are unable to be perfectly still and unmoveable. Even Jesus was finite in one sense, and thus, understands and sympathizes with our weakness.

The Physicality of Virtue article⁴ says that emotions, thoughts, and reason, and all the primitive emotions and functions of the brain are still related with the higher things - such as spirit and mind. Descartes wanted

⁴ Vesely, Patricia. 2022. "The Physicality of Virtue in Job 31: The Use of Bodily Terms in Job's Depiction of Moral Integrity." *The Journal of Theological Studies* 73 (1): 1–21. doi:10.1093/jts/flac004.

to separate the lower and higher thoughts - emotions and virtue - but according to this article, the lower and higher are one and the same. Also, he argues that this combination of the two is the teaching of Job and the Bible. I want to examine these claims. I believe that ultimately a person is a unified whole. That even the skin cells are affecting our decisions when we decide to fold or go all in. This is theory of connectedness and philosophy and science. However, how connected is the lower and the higher? According to the article, it was thought that "virtue can subdue or even suppress the body and its passions." This is true in my mind. The only problem is, it may be a higher emotion and passion that is suppressing lower passions. It may be one substance, but there are priorities to the passions, which is probably in congruence with modern neuroscience, where there is a rational and cognitive mind, and there is a primitive amygdala. But the only problem is, the lower passion causes the higher passion to activate - thus, is the lower passion the ultimate cause of the higher passion? And another truth is that all our passions cannot be inhibited completely at all times, and thus, virtue is not perfectly inhibiting everything. My conclusion is that Job teaches us that physical sickness tests our virtue, and our emotions, thoughts, and sayings, and even small actions and behavior shows what kind of virtue we have. Thus, we must be

purified truly inside and out, and be holy and good. We should not have inner passions battling our outer virtue, but rather have peace. We should be truly good, rather than forcing it. God is testing our hearts, and if we are truly good, we will be good even when there is a lot of temptation and passion to do otherwise.

The next article⁵ speaks of how God tests Job to see if Job fears God because God gave him wealth or because of his righteousness. Fear of the Lord is the topic of this article, and I wish to define it. Fear of God is a good thing - it is an understanding that God will destroy the wicked if you sin. Because you know that God will punish sin, you do good things. It is essentially loving goodness and hating evil. The two go hand in hand. But why does Job fear God? Is it because he was protected and has good things from God? Or is it because he truly wants to be good and hates evil? Satan hates humans and God and so he wants to test. And God knows that Job is truly blameless and loves God and fears God for the right reasons. And so God tests Job, and Job says “Naked I came and naked I will go.” This shows that it is not the blessings Job received that caused him to fear God. The conclusion is: we should fear God because of the

⁵ Schwáb, Zoltán S. 2022. “Does the Reader Fear God for Nothing?: A Theological Reflection on the Divine Speeches in Job.” *The Journal of Theological Studies* 73 (2): 439–73. doi:10.1093/jts/flac078.

right reasons, which is the love of God and love of good and desire to do good and understanding that evil leads to pain and punishment.

In conclusion, the fear of the Lord is one of the topics of wisdom literature. Job teaches us that we should fear God and love goodness and hate evil. Job teaches us the meaning of life, which is something that postmodernists may have gotten right - we cannot find the exact meaning of life. But Job says that although we may not know the meaning of life, God does - because God and Satan are duking it out in the heavenly realms. Thus, the meaning of life is ultimately to trust God even though we don't know. Zeno shows us that Job was the right way to live because even though Job suffered greatly, he endured to the end. Ultimately, Job teaches us that God is good, and that he rewards righteousness, so we should seek to endure suffering like a good soldier and love God no matter what.

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